



Landing a quant job: what you need to know

Career paths, interviews, desk culture, certifications: a map to navigate quant recruiting.

CLASSIC INTERVIEW REFLEX

Pricing a call with no closed-form formula? → binomial tree or Monte Carlo simulation

TYPICAL CAREER PATHS

- Master's or PhD in quantitative finance, applied mathematics or engineering.
- Common transitions from physics, computer science or actuarial science.
- Internships/apprenticeships often matter more than the degree alone.

QUANT INTERVIEWS

- Probability brainteasers, stochastic calculus, coding (often Python).
- "By hand" pricing questions with no access to a ready-made formula.
- Reasoning out loud often matters more than the final correct answer.

DESK CULTURE

- Fast pace, direct and concise communication, high pressure during volatile markets.
- Often flatter hierarchy than elsewhere, but a strongly meritocratic environment.
- Networking weighs heavily on access to opportunities.

USEFUL CERTIFICATIONS

- CFA: the generalist reference in asset management and financial analysis.
- FRM: focused on financial risk management.
- CQF: more technical, geared toward pricing and quantitative modeling.

Who uses what?

JUNIOR CANDIDATE

Prepares brainteasers, stochastic calculus and coding for technical interviews.

CAREER SWITCHER

Often relies on the CQF or FRM to validate a move into quant finance.

M1/M2 STUDENT

Stacks internships and networking on top of coursework to stand out.

RECRUITER

Evaluates rigor of reasoning as much as pure technical skills.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. In a quant interview, explaining your reasoning often matters more than finding the right answer instantly.
2. Networking isn't optional: a large share of quant opportunities are decided before a formal application is even submitted.
3. Certifications (CFA/FRM/CQF) are credibility accelerators, not substitutes for solid hands-on experience.



Comparison table

CERTIFICATION	TYPICAL DURATION	FOCUS	USEFULNESS FOR A QUANT ROLE
CFA	2-4 years (3 levels)	Financial analysis, asset management	Useful in portfolio management, less so for pure pricing
FRM	1-2 years (2 levels)	Risk management	Highly relevant for risk management roles
CQF	6 months to 1 year	Pricing and quantitative modeling	The most directly aligned with a quant pricing role

Real-world examples

PROBABILITY BRAINTEASER

"On average, how many coin flips does it take to get two heads in a row?" — tests rigor of reasoning more than knowledge of a formula.

PRICING CASE INTERVIEW

You're asked to structure, verbally and without notes, how to price a simple exotic option from first principles.

STOCHASTIC CALCULUS QUESTION

"Apply Itô's lemma to a function of Brownian motion" — tests command of the mathematical fundamentals of pricing.

TAKE-HOME TEST

An exercise to complete at home (often in Python) to assess the ability to structure a real end-to-end project, not just answer verbally.

Quick glossary

BRAINTEASER

Logic or probability question used to test reasoning during an interview.

FIT INTERVIEW

Interview focused on motivation and cultural fit with the team.

TAKE-HOME TEST

Technical exercise completed independently before a final interview.

NETWORKING

Actively building a professional network, often decisive for accessing quant opportunities.

DESK

Trading or management team organized around an asset class or strategy.

BUY-SIDE VS SELL-SIDE

Investors (buy-side: asset managers, hedge funds) vs intermediaries (sell-side: banks).

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